

The Global Burden of Mental Illness

Prevalence, Impact, and the Treatment Gap

A data-driven overview of global mental health conditions, their disease burden, and the persistent gap between need and treatment.

Global data · 2023

Our World in Data / IHME



Hundreds of Millions Affected

Lifetime depression risk is substantial, while mental health conditions range from common disorders to less common but severe illnesses.

1 in 3

women will experience major depression in their lifetime



Two highlighted figures ≈ 1 in 3

1 in 5

men will experience major depression in their lifetime



One highlighted figure = 1 in 5



Policy relevance: common disorders such as depression and anxiety affect many people; schizophrenia and bipolar disorder are less common but have large impacts on individuals’ lives.

Source: Our World in Data mental health brief; prevalence estimates refer to major depression lifetime risk.

Depression and Anxiety Dominate

DALYs per 100,000 people by mental illness category, World, 2023.



DALYs combine years of life lost due to premature death and years lived with disability.

≈80%

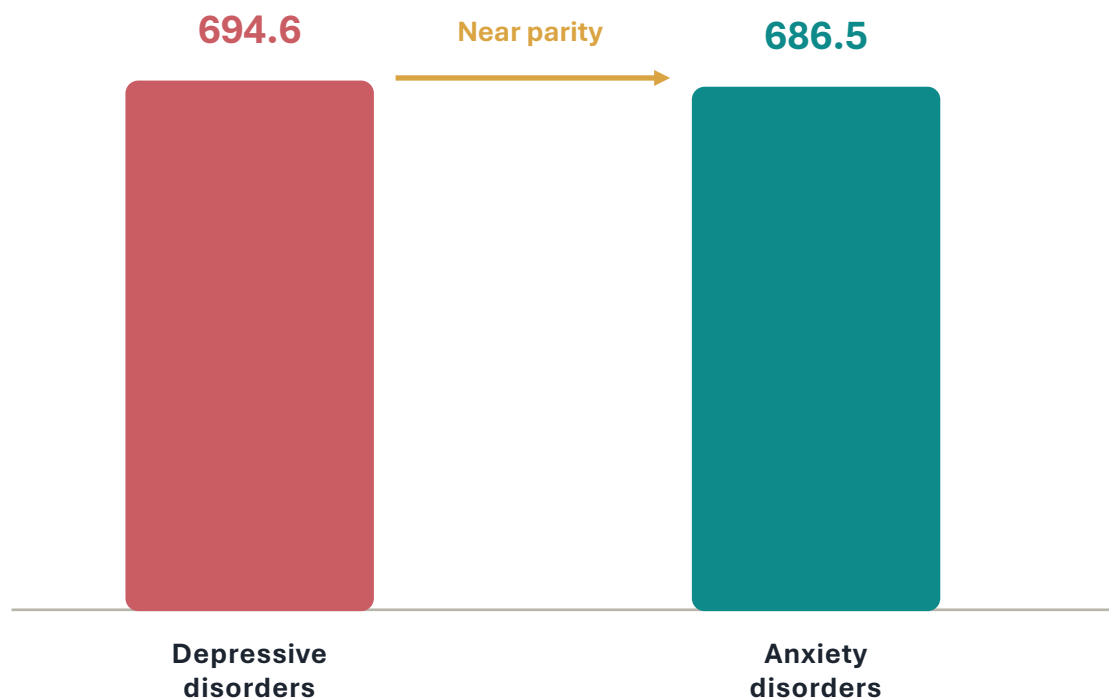
of the total burden across these five categories comes from depression and anxiety combined.

Central comparison: common disorders drive the greatest population-level disease burden.

Data source: IHME Global Burden of Disease (2025), as cited by Our World in Data.

Depression and Anxiety Carry Nearly Equal Burden

Their DALY rates differ by only 8.1 per 100,000 people.



Why it matters

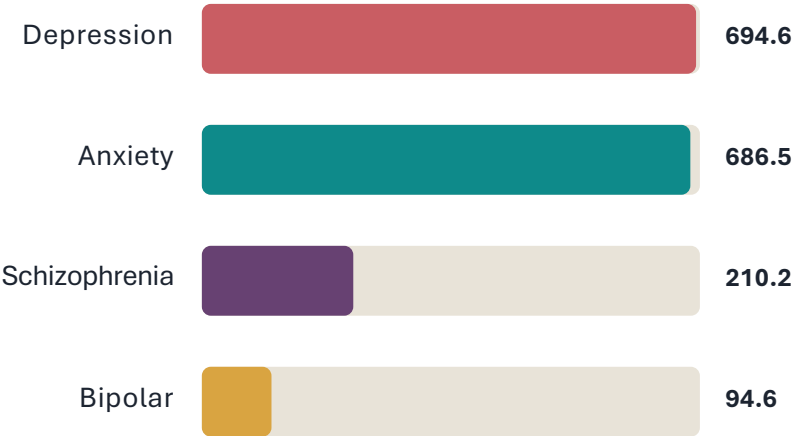
- Depression and anxiety together dominate the global mental health burden.
- Their similar DALY rates argue for scaling treatment capacity across both conditions.
- Other categories are important but much smaller at population level.

Difference: 8.1 DALYs per 100K

Source: DALY figures from the brief's Disease Burden by Category table.

Severe Conditions: Lower Prevalence, High Individual Impact

Schizophrenia and bipolar disorder contribute less population-level burden than depression/anxiety, yet can be highly disabling for affected individuals.



Same scale: DALYs per 100,000



Schizophrenia contributes 210.2 DALYs per 100K — lower than depression/anxiety, but reflecting severe disability.



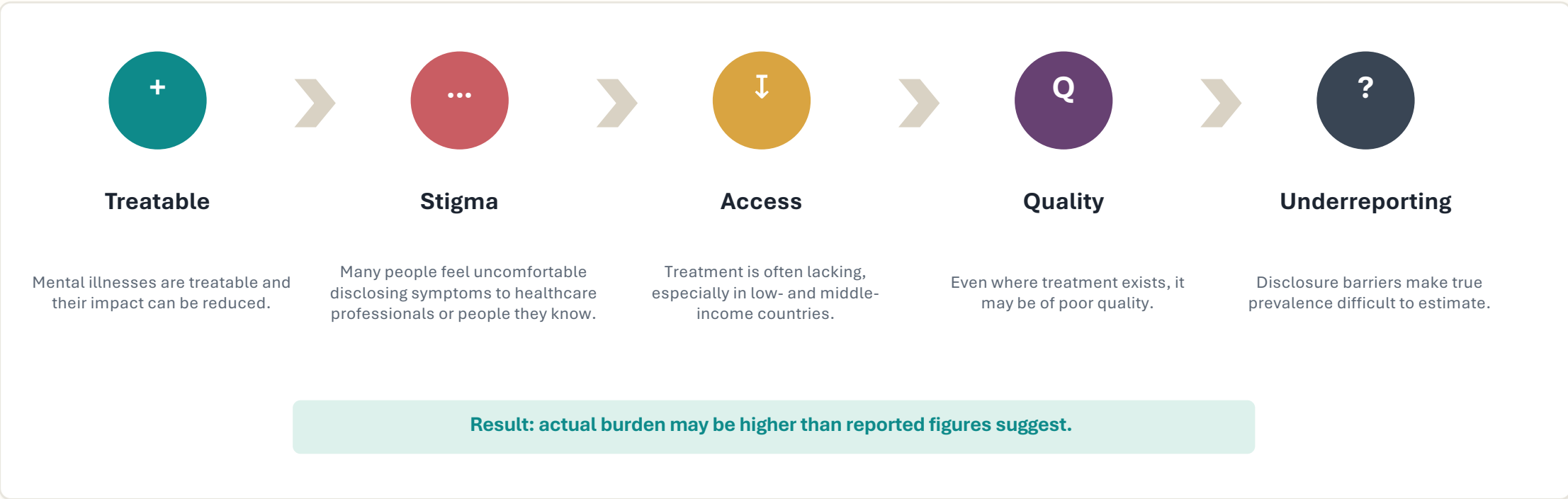
Bipolar disorder contributes 94.6 DALYs per 100K and remains a meaningful source of burden.

Planning implication: scale broad care for common disorders while maintaining care for severe conditions.

Source: Our World in Data / IHME DALY figures; prevalence language from source brief.

Treatment Is Available — but Often Lacking or Poor Quality

Effective treatments exist, yet stigma, access constraints, and quality problems create a persistent gap.



Source: Treatment gap and data challenge claims are taken directly from the source brief.

How People Cope: Medication, Faith, and Family Conversations

Global survey data shows responses to anxiety or depression vary widely across countries and cultures.



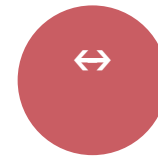
Prescribed medication

Common in higher-income settings



Religious or spiritual activities

Prevalent in many regions worldwide



Friends or family

A widely reported coping mechanism

Policy interventions must account for cultural, economic, and healthcare-system differences — not apply one-size-fits-all responses.

Source: Global survey coping strategy summary from Our World in Data mental health brief.

Key Takeaways

Prioritize depression, anxiety, and closing the treatment gap — while maintaining care for severe conditions.

01

Depression and anxiety together represent the overwhelming majority of mental health DALYs across the five categories.

02

Schizophrenia and bipolar disorder carry disproportionate individual burden and require maintained care.

03

Treatment exists, but access and quality remain inadequate in many settings.

04

Stigma suppresses help-seeking and accurate data, so burden is likely underestimated.

05

Scale effective and safe treatment for common disorders while maintaining care for severe conditions.

Planning frame

Scale treatment
capacity



Maintain severe-
condition care